The Boy Who Fell into a Book

By Alan Ayckbourn

Suggested Roles:

ACTOR 1: *Kevin, Little Man, Woman/Wolf*
ACTOR 2: *Dad, Voice/Rock, Monique, R-Hood*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Kevin's bedroom – Kevin is in bed, reading aloud.

KEVIN: **(Pg 1-3)** . . . Rockfist Slim, ace detective, fought like a crazed tiger. Whap! One evil-looking opponent crashed to the ground. Aaargggh! Another thug flew helplessly through the air, victim to our hero's well-oiled combat skills. But still they kept coming. The underworld leader known only as the Green Shark was taking no chances. Eventually, sheer numbers bore Rockfist to the ground *(gasp)* Semi-conscious but still struggling, Rockfist was dragged across the concrete floor. A door clanged behind him. *(clang)* Rockfist found himself in deep, impenetrable darkness . . .

DAD: *(off stage)* Kevin! It's half past ten. Go to sleep. I've told you before, if you want to read, read in the daytime.

KEVIN: *(disgruntled)* Yes, Dad. *(turns off the light, waits a few seconds then switches it on again)*

DAD: *(immediately)* Kevin!

KEVIN: *(swiftly switches off the light, grumbling)* How can I sleep till I know what happens to Rockfist? He's trapped. He could be dying! *(he ponders as he drifts off to sleep)* The trouble with a book . . . a good book . . . it's inside your head . . . and you're like inside the book . . . it becomes *(yawn)* . . . part of you . . . *(yawn)* really real . . .

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *I admit it. I love to read. Getting lost in a good book is one of my favorite things.*
ACTOR 2: *But in this selection, if you are **lost** in a story, bookmarks are useless and page numbers become portals.*
ACTOR 1: *Buckle up, because Kevin's literary shenanigans are about to begin.*
ACTOR 2: *Can he and Rockfist Slim save the world one story at a time?*
TOGETHER: *The Boy Who Fell into a Book by Alan Ayckbourn*

KEVIN: **(Pg 3-7)** *(clearly dreaming of falling; he awakes suddenly when he hits the ground)*

VOICE: *(from the darkness)* Hold it right there, kid.

KEVIN: *(jumping)* Who's that?

VOICE: *(lying)* I've got a .45 pointing straight at you. Put up your hands and throw down your gun.

KEVIN: I can't. I haven't got a gun. *(he holds up his arms and show his empty hands)*

VOICE: Who are you? What are you doing here?

KEVIN: My name is Kevin Carter and this is my bedroom. *(suddenly doubtful)* At least it was a minute ago. Who are you and what are you doing here?

ROCK: *(click of a cigarette lighter; Rockfist steps onstage)* The name's Rockfist Slim, kid.

KEVIN: *(in wonder)* You're Rockfist Slim? ***Rockfist Slim?*** *(quickly figuring it out)* You've been shut in here by the Green Shark's men, haven't you?

ROCK: *(menacingly)* How do you know about the Green Shark?

KEVIN: *(rapidly)* I was in bed reading a book called *Rockfist Slim and the Case of the Green Shark* and dad told me to turn out the light, and then suddenly I was falling, and the next minute I ended up here. I seem to have – fallen in. *(excited)* We're both in a book!

ROCK: Listen. I have less than 72 hours before the Green Shark destroys half the planet. **(Pg 8-9)** and I'm trapped in here with a lunatic kid. I don't even like kids. I hate kids. Get off my planet.

KEVIN: I'll do a deal with you. If you help me get home – I'll help you solve your case. I have your book. I could skip on ahead – find out what happens.

ROCK: Could you find out the identity of the Green Shark? If I knew his identity I could

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stop him.

KEVIN: **(Pg 10)** Is it a deal?

ROCK: *(reluctantly)* It's a deal. *(they shake hands)* Now stand back. I'm going to charge that door. *(he rushes the door, bounces off and returns clutching his shoulder)* Let's start looking for another way out. **(Pg 15-16)** *(they start to move off. Monique appears and blocks their path)*

MONIQUE: *(French, beautiful, with a gun)* *Monsieur Rockfist Slim, quel pleasant surprise.*

KEVIN: *(under his breath)* It's Monique La Sleek, deadly #1 henchperson of the Green Shark - blackmailer, thief and murderer. *(ominous sound effect)*

ROCK: Run for it, kid! **(Pg 20)** *(they rush out – a whirl of sound and we are in a new location – a forest – they look around bewildered)* **(Pg 39-40)** Is this your bedroom?

KEVIN: I don't have trees growing in my bedroom. Do you think Monique's following us?

ROCK: I wouldn't be surprised. . . **(Pg 43)** I know too much. **(Pg 40)** What books have you got with forests in them?

KEVIN: I don't know. Dozens.

ROCK: Dozens? *(looking at his watch)* I can't spend time going through dozens of books! **(Pg 41)** I mean we could be anywhere from *Huckleberry Finn* to *The Boys' Book of Nature Walks.*

LITTLE MAN: **(Pg 42)** *(hopping on one leg, gleefully)* Today I back, tomorrow I brew,
The next I'll have the young Queen's child.
Ha! Glad I am that no one knew,
That Rumpelstiltskin I am styled. *(he hops off)*

ROCK: What in the heck -- ?

KEVIN: That's where we are! *Grimm's Fairy Tales*. *(beat)* Look! Through the trees. It's a cottage. In the clearing. **(Pg 44-45)** *(They reach the cottage – Kevin knocks – no answer – he tries the door handle – CREAK – the door swings open)* Hallo! Anyone home? *(to Rock)* Come on. Let's look inside! *(Rock follows Kevin inside)*

ROCK: Kid, listen. I might not read much, but I know this. No good comes of pushing

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your way into cottages in the middle of deep woods. In my experience, 20 minutes later 3 angry bears show up.

KEVIN: I wonder if there's any food. I'm hungry.

ROCK: Don't touch the food! You eat it, you'll turn into something. Or you'll shrink. You'll be 2 inches high, going through little doors and meet caterpillars . . .

KEVIN: That's *Alice in Wonderland*.

ROCK: These are dangerous places, kid. Before you know it, you're kissing frogs, dogs are singing, and giants aren't far away.

WOMAN: **(Pg 46-47)** *(appears behind Rock, stands watching him until he turns in fear)*

Hallo, my friends, please have no fear,

For you are very welcome here.

ROCK: *(out of the corner of his mouth)* Kid . . . hey, kid. Hey! *(to woman, clearly unnerved)* All we really want are some directions, ma'am.

WOMAN: *(silence creepy staring)*

ROCK: Why don't she answer me?

KEVIN: I've just remembered. Grimm's fairy tales is in verse. That may be the only way she'll understand us.

WOMAN: Do come inside and take a seat.

My granddaughter you soon can meet. *(She goes out)*

KEVIN: **(Pg 49-50)** Only to talk to her. If we don't talk in rhyme, she won't know what we're saying.

ROCK: Who is she? Any clues? There's no sign of a bear and she certainly ain't Snow White.

KEVIN: She's not the witch from Hansel and Gretel. Otherwise this house would be made of gingerbread.

ROCK: Didn't she say something about meeting a granddaughter?

BOTH: *(simultaneously)* Little Red Riding Hood!

WOMAN: *(returns with a tray and 2 glasses of lemonade)* The larder's empty I'm afraid. Just

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biscuits and some lemonade.

ROCK: Don't touch the drink! She's spiked it!

KEVIN: What do we do? *(to Woman)* Much as we'd really like to stay . . . *(looks to Rock)*

ROCK: I guess we must be on our way . . .

WOMAN: No, no, this lemon drink is yours.

I squeezed them with my own two . . . hands. *(a unsuppressed snarl, she pushes back her bonnet to reveal two large ears)*

ROCK: (Pg 51) Here come the ears! *(to Kevin)* Let's go!

KEVIN: She's a wolf! *(a loud knock on the door)*

WOLF: (Pg 52-53) *(drops the disguise completely)* Now, not one word from you or him--

Or I will tear you limb from limb. *(moves to the door)*

(in a Granny voice) My dear, you're just in time for tea,

Your granny has come company.

R-HOOD: Oh Grandmama, you've such big ears,

I never noticed, all these years.

And great big hands and, oh, good grief,

You've also got enormous teeth!

ROCK: (Pg 55) This girl's beyond belief *(rushing to R-Hood)*

This ain't your gran, kid, it's not her,

Unless she's grown a coat of fur!

KEVIN: (Pg 51) She's a wolf! **(Pg 56)** Granny's dead.

ROCK: *(quickly rhyming so R-Hood can hear)* He ate her whilst she lay in bed.

(R-HOOD runs away frightened and screaming as the WOLF turns on Rock and Kevin snarling furiously)

ROCK: (Pg 57-58) Let's get out of this place, I'm running out of rhymes. Take my arm here, friend, Your bedroom's just around that bend. *(They exit in a rush as a clap of thunder echoes – they find themselves in an old dark house - spooky)*

KEVIN: (Pg 85) *(looking around cautiously)* I wonder where Monique is? We may have lost her.

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ROCK: Possibly. But knowing her, she's gone on ahead of us. She's waiting for us in the next chapter. *(wind whistles through a broken window)* **(Pg 91)** Where are we now? Break it to me gently. Frankenstein's castle? Edgar Allen Poe land. The Addams Family Home? *(thunderclap)*

KEVIN: I think it's my book of ghost stories!

BOTH: Wah! *(crying out they both race off in opposite directions)*

KEVIN: **(Pg 99-100)** *(racing back on stage – we are back in his bedroom)* I don't believe it. It's my room! I'm home. I'm home! The book. I need the book. *(he grabs it from his nightstand and quickly leafs through the pages)* Rockfist Slim and the Case of the Green Shark.

MONIQUE: Welcome home, Kevin.

KEVIN: *(freezing)* Monique! *(conceals the book)* What are you doing here? What do you want?

MONIQUE: **(Pg 101-102)** I want you to take that book and burn it, Kevin.

KEVIN: If I destroy the book, won't it destroy everything in it. Rockfist? You? The Green Shark. I'll destroy everyone.

MONIQUE: If you finish the book, you will find that I, Monique, die anyway. Killed by the indestructible Rockfist. How do you think it feels to be this superior being, ***moi***, brought down by this gum-chewing little troll? This time, if I die – he will also die!

KEVIN: *(throwing the book at Monique's feet)* You want him dead, you kill him. *(Monique hesitates)* **(Pg 103)** You can't, can you? You can't even pick it up. You can't touch anything here, can you? Not in my world. You don't belong here. You belong in the book. In the real world, you can't hurt me at all. You can't hurt anyone.

MONIQUE: I warn you, Kevin, I will –

KEVIN: Don't threaten me! Get out of my room! Get out of this house!

MONIQUE: *(as she goes)* Keviiiinnnnn! *(shifts to another voice)*

DAD: **(Pg 107)** Kevin! Kevin! Is that light of yours still on!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
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